Harry's Story from 11/22/63

By Stephen King

JAKE: **(Pg 18)** I have never been what you'd call a crying man. My ex-wife, Christy, said that my "nonexistent emotional gradient" was the main reason she was leaving me.

(Pg 19) I can only remember one time when I cried as an adult, and that was when I read the story of the janitor's father. I was sitting along in the teachers' room at Lisbon High School, working my way through a stack of themes that my Adult English class had written. The subject I'd assigned was "The Day That Changed My Life." **(Pg 20-21)** There were no violins or warning bells when I pulled the janitor's theme off the top of the stack, no sense that my little life was about to change. But we never know, do we? Life turns on a dime.

I remember how his theme started. I remember it word for word.

> *"It wasn't a day but a night. The night that changed my life was the night my father murdirt my mother and two brothers and hurt me bad. He hurt my sister too, so bad she went into a comah. In three years she died without waking up. Her name was Ellen and I loved her very much."*

It was when I got to the part about him crawling under the bed with blood running in his eyes that I began to cry.

I had thought he was slower than the rest. Well, by God, there was a reason for that, wasn't there? And a reason for the limp, too. It was a miracle he was alive at all. [Just] a nice man who would be a janitor for the rest of his life. Maybe once he could have been something different, but one night his life turned on a dime and now he was just a guy the kids called Hoptoad Harry because of the way he walked. So I cried and stroked a big red A+ on top of his paper.

INTRODUCTION

Life-changing moments. Single acts that so profoundly affect your life, you know you'll never be the same. Moments that have the power to transform lives and shape destinies. Jake Epping is moved by the raw honesty of Harry's essay. But he never realized that Harry's life-changing moment would become his too.

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If you had a chance to go back in time and change history, would you do it? And what would happen if you did? Would you change . . .

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JAKE: **(Pg 24-25)** Two years later, on the last day of the school year, Harry Dunning limped up to me after homeroom period and offered me his hand.

HARRY: I just want to thank you for everything

JAKE: You already did that, as I remember.

HARRY: Yeah, but this is my last day. I'm retiring. I'll never forget that A-plus. I framed that, too. Got it right up beside my diploma.

JAKE: Good for you. *(to audience)* And it was. It was all good. His essay had been primitive art, but every bit as powerful and true as any painting by Grandma Moses. In spite of his grammatical lapses, Harry Dunning had written like a hero. On one occasion, at least. **(Pg 26)** The intercom on the wall cleared its throat.

INTERCOM: Mr. Epping, you have a phone call -- Al Templeton.

JAKE: *(to audience)* Al Templeton, owner of Al's Diner. Curious as to why Al would call me. Ours had always been strictly a cook-and-client relationship. *(goes to phone, punches in his extension)*

AL: **(Pg 27-28)** Jake, I need to see you. It's important.

JAKE: Can I ask—

AL: I expect you to ask plenty, and I'll answer, but not over the phone.

JAKE: I promised I'd come down in an hour or so. And he hung up, without even a goodbye. Al's Diner was housed in a silver trailer across the tracks from Main Street, in the shadow of the old Worumbo mill. I went up the steps, then paused. The sign WELCOME TO AL'S DINER, HOME OF THE FATBURGER! was gone. In its place was a square of cardboard CLOSED & WILL NOT REOPEN DUE TO ILLNESS. THANK YOU FOR YOUR BUSINESS OVER THE YEARS & GOD BLESS.

What kind of serious illness came on in 24 hours? I left Al's last night at 5:45 and he'd been fine. The door opened while I was reaching for the handle, and Al stood there looking at me,

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not smiling. Al was seriously ill. I could see that. **(Pg 29)** In the hours since I'd last seen him, Al Templeton appeared to have lost at least 30 pounds. Nobody loses 30 pounds in less than a day, *nobody*.

AL: How do you like the new me, Jake? I've got a lot to talk about and I think you're the only one who might listen. **(Pg 32)** I want you to see something. It'll be quicker that way. Only ***seeing*** isn't the right word. I guess ***experiencing*** is a lot closer."

JAKE: **(Pg 33)** He led me past the double grill, the sink, the FrostKing fridge and the freezer. He stopped in front of the dishwasher and pointed to the door at the far end of the kitchen.

AL: That's it. Through that door. You need to find out for yourself.

JAKE: **(Pg 34)** I'd be lying if I said my heart didn't kick into a higher gear when I turned the knob and pulled. But when Al reached past my shoulder and turned on the light, what I saw was—Well, a pantry. *(to Al)* How long is this going to take, Al?

AL: **(Pg 36)** I want you to give me your cell phone, your wallet, and all the money you have in your pockets, coins included. Please. ***Please,*** Jake. *(Jake hands over the items)* [And] It'll take as long as you want, because it'll only take two minutes. It always takes two minutes.

JAKE: **(Pg 38)** I did as he asked, feeling like the world's biggest dope. One step . . . lowering my head to keep from scraping it on the aluminum ceiling . . . two steps . . . now actually crouching a little. A few more steps and I'd have to get on my knees. That I had no intention of doing, dying man's request or not. *(to Al)* Al, this is stupid . . .

AL: **(Pg 39-40)** Go on. Nothing's going to happen to you, buddy. Just go on.

JAKE: So I did. God help me, I did. And all at once there was a pop inside my head, exactly like the kind you hear when you're in an airplane and the pressure changes suddenly. I was no longer in the pantry. I was no longer in Al's Diner, either. I *was* outside but the diner was gone.

AL: **(Pg 41)** You can come back the same way you got there. Feel for the steps. Look around a little, then come back.

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JAKE: It was Al's voice, but very faint. *(looking around incredulously)* **(Pg 48)** On the left was a rack of newspapers. No *New York Times,* but there were copies of the *Portland Press Herald* and one leftover *Boston Globe.* The dates on both were Tuesday, September 9, 1958.

AL: **(Pg 53)** Relax Jake. You're back. What do you think?

JAKE: How long was I gone?

AL: Two minutes. I told you, it's always two minutes. And it's always 11:58 A.M. September 9, 1958. Every trip is the first trip.

JAKE: You found this by accident?

AL: The first time, I actually ***fell*** down those stairs, like Alice into the rabbit-hole. I thought I'd gone insane. *(begins violently coughing)*

JAKE: **(Pg 54)** *He can't go on this way. He's no more than a week from the hospital, and probably just days.* And wasn't that why he'd called me. Because he had to pass on this amazing secret to somebody before the cancer shut his lips forever.

AL: **(Pg 65)** You can go back, Jake. You can change history. Do you understand that? **(Pg 83)** John Kennedy can live. You can save him, Jake.

JAKE: And would that really make things better? There were no guarantees. I told him goodnight and left. [But] one more thought came before I dropped: **(Pg 84)** *It wasnt a day but a night. The night that change my life was the night my father murdirt my mother and two brothers. . . .* **(Pg 85)** I ran for my study. I don't keep all student work, but I made it a habit of photocopying the best essays. I pulled open the bottom drawer and after 15 minutes, I found it . . . *I never go see horra movies because on Halloween night in 1958 I lived thru one.*

AL: **(Pg 65)** *(Echoing)* You can go back, Jake. You can change history.

********The Next Day at Al's Diner *******

AL: **(Pg 87)** *(reading Harry Dunning's essay)* Jesus! Son of a b*** killed his wife and three of his kids with a hammer?

JAKE: **(Pg 89)** It took Harry years to recover from that night. Could [his life] have been better? Yes. Can I make that happen? Based on yesterday, maybe I can. **(Pg 90)** If I can stop his old

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man from swinging that hammer. And the three other kids. Surely some of them will get married if they live to grow up. I want a better example of what happens when you change a watershed moment. I need that before I go monkeying with something as big as the Kennedy assassination.

(Pg 116) Forty minutes later I was headed north to Derry behind the wheel of a 1954 Ford **(Pg 165)** In the weeks before Halloween, I came to believe that Derry wasn't like other places. Derry wasn't right. Something wrong, something bad. Certain empty houses that seemed to stare like the faces of people suffering from terrible mental illness. An empty playground with the roundy-round slowly spinning even though there were no kids to push it and no wind to turn it. It screamed on its hidden bearings. Something wrong, something bad. **(Pg 167-168)** I anticipated no problems when Halloween came. Dunning might come in his car rather than on foot, but I knew what it looked like. It would be after dark, according to Harry's essay, but there were streetlights. Unless he was totally fixated on what he'd come to do, Dunning would almost certainly see me running at him. I had the pistol, but it was only dead accurate up to fifteen yards. I couldn't wait until he actually got in the house because according to the essay, by the time Harry came out of the bathroom, all of them but Ellen were dead. I hadn't traveled across more than half a century to save just one of them. **(Pg 188)** Ten minutes until the start of *The New Adventures of Ellery Queen.* How far along had *Ellery Queen* been when Dunning arrived? Harry's theme hadn't said, but I was guessing not long. **(Pg 191-192)** I heard a car moving far faster than any reasonable driver would have dared to travel on a street that was no doubt full of children wearing masks and carrying trick-or-treat bags. I knew who it was even before it screeched to a stop. Inside 379, Doris Dunning was sitting on the couch with Troy while Ellen pranced around in her Indian princess costume. *Even if it kills me,* I thought. *Even then. Because this is* now. *This is* them.

The back door would be locked. I was so sure of this that I almost tumbled off the stoop when the knob turned and it swung outward. I stepped into a kitchen that still smelled of the pot roast Mrs. Dunning had cooked I heard her say "Frank? What are you doing here? What is that? Why have you. . . *get out of here!"* Then she screamed.

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I ran through the arch and stopped there with my mouth open. Doris was on the living room rug. He had already broken her arm and dislocated her shoulder as well. He grabbed Ellen by her hair and heaved her. *(shouting)* ***DUNNING! STOP!***

(Pg 193) I pulled the trigger of the revolver. The bullet took him in the shoulder. He twisted sideways with the impact, then came on again.

HARRY: *(as a child with his air rifle)* Stop it, Daddy! Stop or I'll shoot you!

JAKE: Arthur "Tugga" Dunning was crawling toward me, toward the kitchen. Dunning brought the sledge down on Tugga's head. The boy's face was obliterated. Bone fragments leaped high in the air.

I fired again. **(Pg 194)** Dunning went down, feet in the living room, head in the archway between the living room and the kitchen. All of this happened in less than a minute; maybe only 30 seconds. Life turns on a dime, and when it does, it turns fast. *(to Troy)* *Get out! Take your sister and get out!*

JAKE: **(Pg 196)** I went into the bathroom, grabbed a towel, scrubbed my bloody face and stepped out into the kitchen. The boy who had brought me here was standing on the faded linoleum by the stove and watching me. Although it had probably been six years since he'd sucked his thumb, he was sucking it now. His eyes were wide and solemn, swimming with tears. Here was a boy who had just experienced something that would no doubt traumatize him, but he was also a boy who would never grow up to become Hoptoad Harry. Or to write a theme that would make me cry.

HARRY: Who are you, mister?

JAKE: Nobody. *(to audience)* He deserved more than that, though. The sirens were closer now, but I turned back. *(to Harry)* Your good angel. *(to audience)* Then I slipped out the back door and into Halloween night of 1958.

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JAKE: **(Pg 197)** [When I returned to the diner] I thought of Harry, unhurt. And Ellen, who wasn't deep in a coma from which she would never emerge. And Troy. And Doris. Her badly broken

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arm might hurt her for the rest of her life, but at least she was going to ***have*** a life.

(whispering) I did it, Al (to audience) But what had I done to 2011?

(Pg 213-214) I dialed directory assistance. There was no listing for Doris, Troy, or Harold Dunning in Derry. As a last resort I tried Ellen. Halfway through the fourth ring, a woman answered.

JAKE: I knew your brother Harry a long time ago. I thought maybe I'd try to get in touch.

ELLEN: Well, I'm sorry to tell you this, but Harry's dead. A long time ago. In Vietnam. During the Tet Offensive.

JAKE: Oh God, I'm so sorry. *(to audience)* I sat down, feeling sick to my stomach. I'd saved him from a limp and some mental fogginess only to cut his lifespan by forty years or so? Terrific. The surgery was a success, but the patient died.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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